

Reader-Response Journal Prompts¹

How the Author Writes

- Topic: What was his or her subject? Why this topic?
- Plot: What happened; what were the events of the story?
- Pace: How quickly or slowly did the author move the plot? Was it gradual enough to be believable and keep you involved? Fast enough to hold a reader's interest? Was there too much action and not enough character development?
- Plausibility/Believability: Did the plot ring true? Would characters act and react this way? Were the circumstances believable? Did it matter?
- Description and detail: Could we see it happening? Feel it? Hear it? Too little description? Too many details?
- Dialogue: Was the talk realistic? Could we hear the individual characters' voices? Too much dialogue? Too little? What did the dialogue show about the moods, ages, intentions, and backgrounds of the characters?
- Flashbacks, flash-forwards, and foreshadows: How did the author use shifts in time, and why?
- Emotions: Did the reader laugh? Cry? Why?
- Setting: What time and place did the author choose? Why? Was the setting important to the story? Was it convincing/believable? Confusing?
- Main characters: Who were they? How can you tell who the main character is?
- Character development: How were characters introduced and developed? How were their actions, thoughts, and feelings depicted? Were they believable? Could you enter characters' hearts and minds and see through their eyes? Which characters did you relate to? Did the reader care about what happened to any of them? Did any of them remind you of characters from movies, plays, or other novels? Of people from the reader's real life?
- Titles: Did it fit? Was it a grabber? Did it give too much away?
- Theme: What ideas about life and living come through the story?
- Problem: What was the issue for the main character to try to resolve?
- Suspense: Did you wonder what would happen next? How did the author establish a suspenseful tone? Did the author surprise you?
- Formula: Could you predict too easily what was going to happen? Was it too much like other books by this author or from this genre?

¹ Adapted from Nancie Atwell's *In the Middle* (1998)

- Conventions: Did you notice short paragraphs or chapters? Sentence fragments? Why did the author write this way?
- Information: Were there enough specifics about character, action, background, and setting? Was there too much information? Irrelevant/Not important information?
- Specific information: What did you learn about the world— about history, art, politics, science, etc.—through the narrative?
- Length: Was this book too long? Too short?
- Point of view: Who told the story? What voice did the author choose: First person? Third person? Single character, dual, multiple, or no character? Why did the author choose this point of view? What were the advantages and drawbacks for you? Where did you stand in relation to the narrator?
- Grace of language: Did the sentences flow? Were they choppy? Did you savor particular phrases and sentences? Was there figurative language? Was there imagery: did the writing create pictures in your mind? Were there sensory details?
- First sentence: How did the author bring you in?
- Lead: How did the author try to keep you there?
- Conclusion: How did the author leave you? Why this ending?
- Prologues: How were these special introductions used and to what effect?
- Epilogues: How was this special conclusion used and to what effect?
- Unusual or experimental narrative techniques: What did you think?
- In-jokes: Did you pick up on inside jokes in the text?

The Author (for those who have read other works by the same author)

- Speculations about, or references to published accounts of, an author's writing processes
- Titles of other books by an author, including sequels, trilogies, and series
- Comparisons with other books by an author
- Comparisons with other authors' styles
- Comparisons with similar books, in terms of topic, genre, or theme, by other authors
- Biographical information about an author
- Publishing-world gossip about an author
- How authors use elements of their own lives and experiences in their fiction
- Other ways authors might have researched their subjects
- News of a new release by an author

Genre

- What are the elements of fiction in this book?
- Novels: What makes a novel a novel?
- Short stories: What makes a short story a short story?
- Poetry: What makes a poem a poem? In what ways does it differ from prose? What are the elements of poetry? How do different poetic techniques affect you?
- Fiction and nonfiction: How do we classify books as one or the other?
- Classification of other books by genre
- Adventure/survival Antiwar Autobiography Biography
- Classic
- Contemporary realistic fiction
- Diary
- Drama
- Epistolary novel family saga
- History
- Historical fiction Horror
- Humor or parody Journalism Legend or myth Memoir Screenplay Mystery
- Nature
- New age
- New journalism Romance
- Science fiction Series novel
- Sports Supernatural Techno-thriller Urban life
- War and espionage Western
- Other kinds of writing one might like to read

Your Strategies

- Choice: How do you decide what to read?
- Place: Did you skim, skip, slow down, regress, speed up, or look ahead? Why? When? What was the effect?
- Abandoning: How and when did you make this decision to abandon the book?
- Rereading: Why did you reread this book? What differences are noted a second time through?
- Revisiting particular parts of a book: Why did you skim back? For pleasure? Clarification?

- Planning: Do you anticipate reading a particular book, author, or genre?
- Predicting: Did you imagine what would happen next? Was the guess correct?
- Revising: Did you consider other ways an author might have written?
- Connecting: Did you relate a book to another book? To a poem or song? To your experiences or feelings?
- Analyzing: What did you think the book was about?
- Length of time it took to read a book Why so long or so quickly?
- Reading rate: How many pages did you read in a half hour? How did you vary your rate depending on the type of book?
- Reading “too easy” books: Why do you need mindless breaks sometimes?
- Difficulty What makes a book a challenge? What do you do when a book is difficult? What do you do when it’s too difficult?
- Schema: Did you have adequate background experience to understand and appreciate this book?
- Unknown Vocabulary: What did you do when you came across an unfamiliar word?
- Contentives, eye fixations, and peripheral vision: What did you notice your eyes doing during reading?
- Rituals: When, how, and where do you read? Why?
- How did you learn to read?
- Do you buy, own, or collect any books?

Your Emotions

- How did the book make you feel?
- What did the book make you think about?
- What do you think or understand that you didn’t think or understand before? What was your involvement with the characters?
- What did you learn about through the story?
- What did you like or dislike about the book?
- What were the best and worst features of the book?
- How would you rate this book?

Recommendations

- Is a book worth recommending?
- Who might enjoy it?

- What reactions did other readers report?
- Who are good authors?
- What are titles of good books?
- What are titles of other good books by this author?
- What titles by other authors address a similar subject or theme? Where could someone who is interested in this book find it?